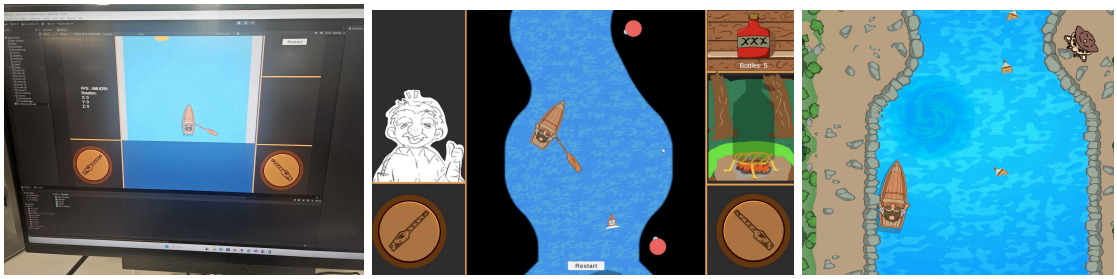
Dev Diary

Xiaoxuan Han

Timeline

As a technical artist, I wasn't entirely sure where to start with this project at first. During the first week, I focused mainly on understanding the game concept and waiting for the designer and engineer to establish the basic structure of the game. As I became more involved in constructing the game directly in the Unity Editor, I gained a better understanding of what needed to be done and where my contributions would have the most impact.

My initial focus was just on creating visual effects and constructing the tilemap. However, as the project progressed while constructing the game, I have also taken on more tasks and became more responsible for the entire development process. I frequently needed to thoroughly playtest, identify visual or technical problems, troubleshoot and fix and test again.



(prototype without shaders -> Shaders added -> tilemap added)

Contributions

My primary contribution was developing the water shader in our boat-rowing game. One good thing in this project was that I was able to reuse and build upon work I had already created. After developing the water shader for the boat-rowing environment, I also adapted that shader into a whirlpool asset. This became an important obstacle in the game and allowed one technical-art solution to serve multiple purposes.

In addition, I created the trail and particle effects of our boat and contributed to the tilemap and environment construction in Unity and spent time playtesting and troubleshooting the environment as the project developed. The part of the process I enjoyed most was seeing the visual effects becoming functional parts of the game.

Communication

Most of the time, the communication in our team happened in the studio in person, where I worked directly with the engineer and designer.

This was especially useful when discussing environment and level details because I could receive immediate feedback and make changes while we were looking at the game together. We also used Discord to share updates when someone was working remotely.

One of the valuable aspects of working this way was how quickly I could learn from the other team members. For example, while I was working on the VFX, our engineer looked at my computer and pointed out that the particle system I was using had been deprecated.
So I researched Unity's Visual Effect Graph and learned how to use the newer system instead of continuing with an outdated workflow. Communication is not only about reporting progress, it is also an important part of learning and problem-solving.